

Northwind Analytics – Employee Handbook

SECTION 1: LEAVE POLICY

1.1 Paid Time Off (Full-Time Employees)

Full-time employees accrue 18 days of paid time off (PTO) per calendar year, accrued monthly at a rate of 1.5 days per month. Unused PTO may be carried over into the following year up to a maximum of 10 days. Any balance beyond 10 days is forfeited on December 31st unless local law requires otherwise.

1.2 Leave Policy for Interns

Interns are not eligible for standard PTO. Instead, interns accrue 1 day of paid leave for every full month of their internship, up to a maximum of 6 days for a standard 6-month internship. Intern leave does not carry over between internship terms and does not carry over if the intern converts to a full-time role; full-time PTO accrual begins fresh on the employee's full-time start date.

1.3 Sick Leave

All employees, including interns, receive 8 paid sick days per year. Sick leave does not carry over year to year. A doctor's note is required for sick leave lasting more than 3 consecutive days.

1.4 Parental Leave

Full-time employees with at least 12 months of tenure are eligible for 16 weeks of paid parental leave following the birth, adoption, or fostering of a child. Interns and employees with less than 12 months of tenure are not eligible for paid parental leave but may request unpaid leave of up to 8 weeks, subject to manager approval.

SECTION 2: REMOTE WORK POLICY

2.1 Eligibility

Employees who have completed their 90-day probationary period are eligible to work remotely up to 3 days per week. Interns are not eligible for remote work and are required to work on-site for the full duration of their internship, except in cases of documented illness.

2.2 Equipment

The company provides a laptop, monitor, and a one-time \$300 home office stipend to employees approved for regular remote work. Interns are provided a laptop only; the home office stipend does not apply to interns.

2.3 Core Hours

All employees, remote or on-site, are expected to be available between 10:00 AM and 4:00 PM in

their local time zone, Monday through Friday, excluding company holidays.

SECTION 3: EXPENSE REIMBURSEMENT

3.1 General Policy

Employees may submit expense reports for business-related travel, client meals, and approved software subscriptions. All expense reports must be submitted within 30 days of the expense being incurred, along with an itemized receipt. Reports submitted after 30 days will not be reimbursed except in exceptional circumstances approved by a director.

3.2 Travel Expenses

Domestic flights must be booked in economy class unless the flight duration exceeds 6 hours, in which case premium economy is permitted. Hotel accommodations are capped at \$220 per night in major metro areas and \$150 per night elsewhere.

3.3 Meals

Meal reimbursement while traveling is capped at \$75 per day, itemized. Alcohol is not reimbursable under any circumstances.

SECTION 4: CODE OF CONDUCT

4.1 Workplace Behavior

All employees are expected to treat colleagues, clients, and partners with respect. Harassment, discrimination, or retaliation of any kind will not be tolerated and may result in immediate termination, regardless of the employee's tenure or role.

4.2 Conflicts of Interest

Employees must disclose any outside employment, board membership, or financial interest that could reasonably be seen as conflicting with Northwind Analytics' business. Disclosures should be made to the employee's manager and to HR within 2 weeks of the conflict arising.

4.3 Confidentiality

Employees, including interns, must sign a confidentiality agreement before their first day. This agreement remains in effect for 2 years following the end of employment, covering client data, trade secrets, and unreleased product plans.

SECTION 5: PERFORMANCE REVIEWS

5.1 Review Cycle

Full-time employees receive formal performance reviews twice a year: a mid-year check-in in June and an annual review in December. New hires receive an additional 90-day review with their manager.

5.2 Intern Reviews

Interns receive a single formal review at the midpoint of their internship and a

final review in the last week of their term. The final review includes a recommendation on whether the intern will be extended an offer for full-time employment.

5.3 Promotion Cycles

Promotions are considered during the December annual review cycle only. Off-cycle promotions require director-level approval and are reserved for exceptional circumstances, such as retention risk or a significant scope change.

SECTION 6: IT AND SECURITY POLICY

6.1 Device Security

All company-issued laptops must have full-disk encryption and the company-managed antivirus agent installed before being used to access internal systems. Personal devices may not be used to access internal systems except through the approved mobile email client.

6.2 Password Requirements

Passwords for internal systems must be at least 14 characters, rotated every 180 days, and must not be reused across the last 10 passwords. Multi-factor authentication is mandatory for all employees and interns accessing company systems remotely.

6.3 Data Classification

Company data is classified as Public, Internal, Confidential, or Restricted. Restricted data (such as customer payment information) may only be accessed by employees who have completed the annual Restricted Data Handling certification.

SECTION 7: COMPANY HOLIDAYS

Northwind Analytics observes 11 paid holidays per year in the United States: New Year's Day, Martin Luther King Jr. Day, Presidents' Day, Memorial Day, Juneteenth, Independence Day, Labor Day, Thanksgiving Day, the day after Thanksgiving, Christmas Eve, and Christmas Day. Employees in other countries follow the locally published holiday calendar for their office.